



THE ANVIL



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JUSTICE FOR GEORGE FLOYD?



George Floyd. Credit: people.com

The recent trial and conviction of Derek Chauvin for the murder of George Floyd was greeted much more with relief in the United States than with either joy or anger. Only the hardest line racists and supporters of the police were angry about the conviction, while only the most politically naive rejoiced.

Police in the US kill an average of over three people every day. The racism that pervades US policing and which dominates the United States as a whole ensures that killer cops are almost always allowed to walk. The system is biased in their favour at every step. They lie about the circumstances of the death. Superiors suppress evidence from reaching the public domain. Mass media largely

report police press releases uncritically. Government officials support them almost every time. And even if the cop is charged and the case reaches court, the prosecution usually runs dead and the jury is stacked.

So how did this particular killer cop get convicted? Fundamentally, it was because of the vast social movement which has built up in the US against police brutality and which had adopted George Floyd's case as its touchstone. Initial media reports of George Floyd's death were based on a police press release saying he had died from a medical emergency while being arrested. It was only the circulation of the video by witnesses that exposed those lies and got Derek Chauvin convicted in the court of public opinion.

The ability of people to use their mobile phones to record videos of police actions now allows the capitalist media's defence system to be broken through. Your average crime reporter is still a stenographer for the cops most of the time, but when video evidence generates community outrage, editors have to choose whether to cover it or ignore it. A cover-up becomes harder to maintain.

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It was precisely because of the accumulated rage that was focused on the pressure point of Chauvin's trial that a cover-up was not attempted there, either. Indeed, Chauvin couldn't find a single serving Minneapolis Police Department copper to testify in his defence. The real defendant in the trial in Minneapolis was the State of Minnesota. Everybody in the US was watching to see if it was prepared to convict a copper who was videoed kneeling on George Floyd's neck for 9 minutes and 29 seconds. And everyone in the US knew the outpouring of rage that would follow an acquittal.

When a police murder is sufficiently blatant and the public anger is sufficiently intense to prevent a cover-up, a Plan B is needed. In this case, it involved sacrificing one copper to save the system of violence. So, as well as the series of coppers testifying against Chauvin, we saw the prosecution presenting this case as an outlier and filling its presentation with pro-police rhetoric. And, once the verdict was in, the entire propaganda machine of US capitalism swung into action. Everyone from the Vice-President down called it a great step forward for the reform of policing and praised the courts of Minnesota for getting it right.

Even here, though, the triumphalism was muted. There could be no wholehearted victory celebrations, because George Floyd was only one of many Black people murdered by US police in recent years. Indeed, while the trial was going

on, protests erupted against the killing of Daunte Wright in the suburbs of Minneapolis by a copper who says she mistook her gun for her taser. And almost as the verdict was being read out, police in Ohio killed Ma'Khia Bryant, a 16 year old Black girl who had called them herself because she was being attacked.

The intractable nature of police brutality in the US has led increasing numbers of Black people there to reject the failed strategy of police reform. Thirty years of "reforms" in Minneapolis have not stopped the MPD from being a pack of murdering racist thugs and the story is the same in Los Angeles, New York, Chicago and many other cities. The demand that is animating grassroots organisations in the US is to defund the cops – i.e. cut their budget. This demand means different things to different people. Democrats who have picked it up talk about sending health professionals instead of cops to deal with mental health crises. The Anarchist position is total abolition of the police and support for this is growing.

The Melbourne Anarchist Communist Group believes that a just society needs no police, no body of armed professionals with special powers not available to the rest of society, who impose the law on the street. We work to build the movement which will make a workers' revolution that abolishes capitalism, abolishes police, smashes the state apparatus and sweeps away racism and all other forms of oppression.

FOR A WORLD WITHOUT POLICE

THE DRUMS OF WAR

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The campaign against China in the capitalist media in Australia has become deafening, with the Government and assorted media outlets going all out to encourage fear and hatred. Two recent developments stand out.



The Australian Army Band Corps
Credit: <https://army.gov.au>

First of all, on 21 April, the Federal Government used recently passed legislation to cancel two agreements between China and Victoria over the Belt and Road Initiative (BRI). These agreements, which imposed no binding obligations on anyone, were important far more for their symbolism than their substance – and so was their cancellation.

The Victorian BRI agreements with China were an obstacle to the capitalist campaign to demonise China and attempt to block its economic development. If you believe what the media are telling you, China is engaging in “debt trap diplomacy”. Its nefarious plan is to seize control of infrastructure around the world by making huge loans that the debtors can never pay back and then take the assets put up as collateral.

There are a couple of problems with this theory. Firstly, China is being accused of doing exactly what Western imperialist countries have been doing for decades. Western governments have been forcing Third World countries with debt problems to sell off their infrastructure on the cheap

as a standard operating procedure. Eventually, people named it neo-liberalism. And secondly, setting up debt traps shows a very short term attitude. There's a lot more power and influence to be gained by financing a viable project that will pay its way.

In reality, what really worries the Australian Government is the prospect of the BRI doing what the Chinese Government says it's about – fostering the economic development of the region. They fear China becoming a developed country, sitting at the centre of a web of economic relations with a string of newly developed Third World countries. That would break up the US-dominated world order set up after World War II. Australian capitalists support this order as the best environment for Australia to be a small-time imperialist in the South Pacific and Timor L'Este.

The other development which is necessary to discuss is the alarming “Drums of War” speech by Michael Pezzullo on Anzac Day. He said:

“In a world of perpetual tension and dread, the drums of war beat – sometimes faintly and distantly, and at other times more loudly and ever closer. Today, as free nations again hear the beating drums and watch worryingly the militarisation of issues that we had, until recent years, thought unlikely to be catalysts for war, let us continue to search unceasingly for the chance for peace while bracing again, yet again, for the curse of war.”

The Government saw Pezzullo's speech in advance and let him make it. Indeed, it fits closely with a similar speech by the Defence Minister, Peter Dutton, on the same day. This sends a clear message to everyone in Australia and to the Chinese

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Government. Though he couched it in terms of a desire for peace, Pezzullo was upping the rhetoric to a level not seen since the 1960s.

The remarkable thing is that the drums of war are being beaten more loudly in Canberra than in Washington or Beijing. The capitalist class here is going further than the US to stoke conflict with China. The reasons for this are unclear at the moment, but may be connected with the relations China is building with a range of South Pacific countries. This gives them an option apart from relying on their current imperialist hegemon, Australia.

Regardless of the reason for Australia's militant anti-China stance, it fits into the growing conflict between the United States and China over China's economic development. If China becomes a developed country, its population of four times the US means its GDP will be much greater than the US. This is incompatible with continued US global dominance and the US capitalists will do everything possible to prevent it.

The real issues with the behaviour of the Chinese so-called “Communist” Party, most importantly its treatment of the Uighur and Tibetan peoples, will not be fixed by the intervention of US imperialism. The attempt to prevent China's economic development is the road to nuclear war. Rather, the Melbourne Anarchist Communist Group puts its faith in the vast Chinese working class. It is in its interests to take up the struggle of China's national minorities against Beijing's great Han chauvinism and genocidal policies. Overthrowing their Stalinist dictators and establishing libertarian communism can't be done without it.

And workers in Australia must silence the drums of war here.

NO WAR ON CHINA!

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MACG

What is Anarchism?

Anarchism is a social philosophy based upon the principles of liberty, equality and solidarity. It is the political dimension of a free society.

What is Communism?

Communism is the principle of “from each according to their ability, to each according to their need”. It is the economic dimension of a free society.

What is the Melbourne Anarchist Communist Group?

The MACG is an organisation of class struggle revolutionary anarchists who share political positions, articulated in theory, strategy and tactics. We aim to encourage struggle by the working class for its own interests and, within that struggle, we aim to advance Anarchist ideas as its necessary philosophical basis.